

Mark Fedenia Baird Professor of Finance

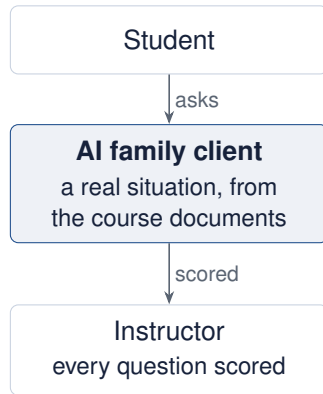
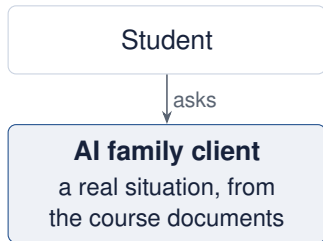
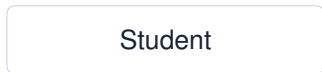
University of Wisconsin–Madison

CS620 Capstone Project · Fall 2026

2026-08-26

Who you are, and the one-line ambition. Do not read the byline aloud.

What it is



What it is

The problem first, the system second. The skill being taught is the uncomfortable conversation, not the arithmetic.



How it works today

- In a browser — **Open WebUI** on a cloud machine
- Roughly **eight containers**, one language model
- The student **types**. The client types back.

It works. Students use it every week.

└ How it works today

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It works. Students use it every week.

Say plainly that it works and is in use. Credibility for everything that follows.

Two ways to make it better

- 1 Make what we have **fast** and **easy to change**.
- 2 Turn the chat box into **someone you talk to**.

└ Two ways to make it better

Name both, briefly. Do not start explaining either one yet.

- 1 Make what we have **fast** and **easy** to change.
- 2 Turn the chat box into **someone you talk to**.

One: solid ground

- Get **current** with the platform, and stay current
- Grading on **the web**, not on a laptop
- **Automatic** deployment and testing

└ One: solid ground

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The unglamorous half. Three items, one sentence each, then move on.

Two: the leap

Today the student *types* a question
and *reads* an answer.

We want them to say it out loud,
to a face that listens and answers back.

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and reads an answer.

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to a face that listens and answers back.

Slow down here. Typing versus speaking is the whole pitch.

Why that matters

In a real meeting you get **one shot**
at the hard question, out loud,
while a family watches you.

**You cannot practise that
with a backspace key.**

└ Why that matters

In a real meeting you get **one shot**
at the hard question, out loud,
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**You cannot practise that
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The strongest thirty seconds in the deck. Let the last line sit before moving on.

The project: evaluate, then build

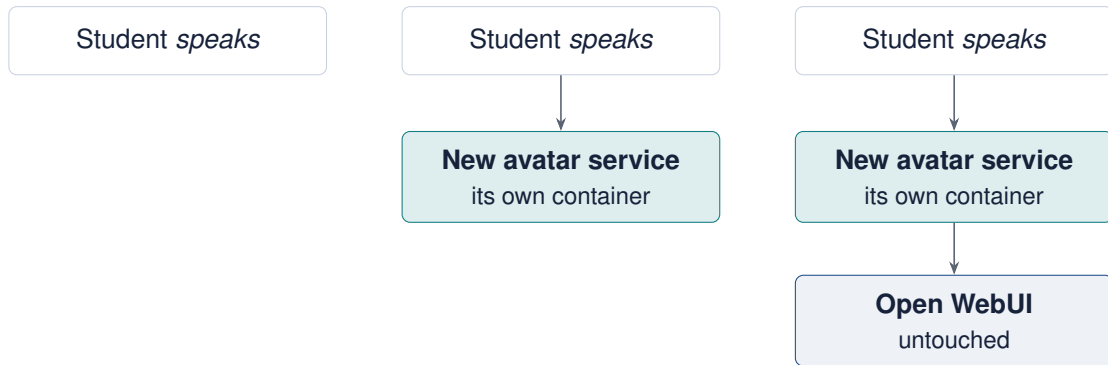
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- **Fast enough?** Under about a second to answer
- **Cheap enough?** Per student, and capped
- **Allowed?** Voice and video are student records

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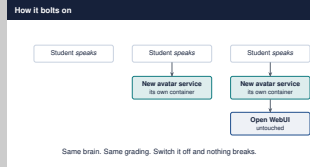
This is the actual capstone work: evaluate, then build. Three criteria, all falsifiable.

How it bolts on



Same brain. Same grading. Switch it off and nothing breaks.

How it bolts on



Answers the question a CS student will ask – does this mean rewriting everything? No.

What we are after

- Students **talking** to it by the end of term
- **Evidence** on whether it makes better advisors
- A finding we publish **either way**

Come build it with us.

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Come build it with us.

Close on the ask. A negative result is still a result, and say so.